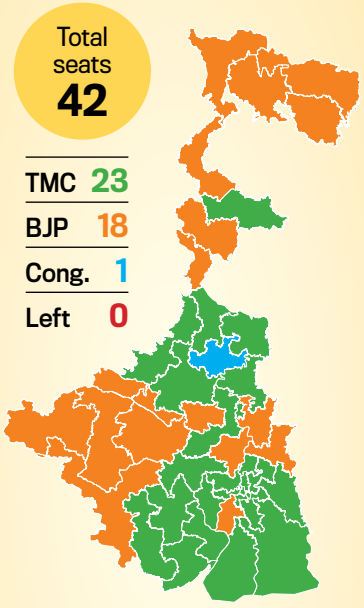
2019 LOK SABHA POLLS IN W. BENGAL



AN ALLIANCE WITH THE TMC, SAYS THE BENGAL CONGRESS, WILL ALIENATE VOTERS AND HELP THE BJP IN THE LS POLLS

group—to keep the Congress under pressure and aligned to their objectives, and not get too bossy.

Mamata herself isn't entirely averse to forming a poll alliance with the Congress in Bengal. Though no official announcement has been made, there's talk of "backchannel" negotiations. In this light, the Bengal Congress leaders told Rahul that in case an alliance with the TMC becomes inevitable, they wouldn't settle for anything less than 8-10 Lok Sabha seats. They also tabled a list of seats where they think they have a chance. Till now, media reports quoting senior TMC and Congress leaders have suggested that Mamata is willing to offer the Congress only two seats—Berhampore and Malda South, the ones it already represents in Parliament. That's what drew the ire of Bengal Congress chief and MP Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury. "Mamata's real intention is clear. Those two seats already have Congress MPs. We won them by defeating Mamata and the BJP. What favour are they doing to us?" he said on January 4.

On December 30, Chowdhury had alleged Mamata was against an alliance. "Didi doesn't want it. Because it would be a problem for her," Chowdhury had said. "We have defeated the TMC and BJP in Berhampore over and over again. Wherever the Congress is strong, it will fight on its own," he had asserted. Taking a dim view of an alliance with the TMC, Chowdhury has alleged that Mamata was conniving with the BJP to hurt the INDIA bloc so that her nephew, TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, could escape the attention of central probe agencies, who are questioning him regarding a few corruption scandals.

Mamata has often been accused by the CPI(M) and the Congress of having a secret understanding with the BJP. The TMC has returned the favour, accusing the Congress and the Left of being the BJP's "B-team" because, in Bengal's context, they inevitably end up dividing anti-saffron votes. The Congress, in turn, cites the TMC's expansionist endeavours in Tripura, Meghalaya and Goa, alleging that in the Meghalaya polls earlier this year, the Trinamool's 13.8 per cent vote share had only hurt the Congress.

Mamata and Abhishek have also often questioned the prospects of the Congress under Rahul's leadership. While the tone had mellowed after the Congress win in Karnataka, its recent defeat in Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh reopened the sluicegates. Mamata called those results "a defeat of the Congress" and "not of the people". Her party's spokesperson Kunal Ghosh added for good measure that Mamata and the TMC, not Rahul and the Congress, should take leadership in the fight against the BJP. Thus, suggesting Kharge's name, Congress leaders feel, is a ploy to undercut the party. "It's clear she is trying to demoralise us and Rahulji," says Nepal Mahato, a senior state Congress leader. "To undermine the Congress and create turbulence in the alliance is her intent." While Kharge, a strong and articulate Dalit leader, is the Congress president, the party has in the past behaved as if Rahul wears an invisible crown and projects him as its face across the country. It has not outright negated the proposal on Kharge, though.

At the INDIA meet, Kejriwal supported Mamata's proposal—he is said to have argued that Kharge's anointment as the face of the bloc will help, inter alia, in the 48 Lok Sabha seats the BJP currently holds where Dalits and Muslims make up around 45 per cent of the electorate. Not counting his native Karnataka, where 25 out of the 28 Lok Sabha seats are with the BJP.

But Mamata didn't just propose Kharge's name; she also said Priyanka Gandhi must be pitted against Narendra Modi as a "strong candidate" from Varanasi, implying that she considers Priyanka to be politically stronger than Rahul to take on the PM. This has aggravated Congress leaders further. "Who is she to decide whom the Congress will field from where? She should know her limits," Mahato says. Left leaders, too, don't shy of painting her as a Trojan horse of the saffron camp. Mohammed Salim, CPI(M) state secretary, says BJP is using Mamata to discredit Rahul after the success of the Bharat Jodo Yatra, and that it was never the intent of the INDIA bloc to come up with a PM face. "The world is seeing a presidentialisation of parliamentary democracy. Modi is trying to do the same with India, where he will be the all-in-all with a defunct Parliament. Mamata has done the same in Bengal," Salim alleges.

Essentially, all three parties act out of enlightened self-interest—mostly that has meant being against each other, so it's natural being together is taking some adjusting to. ■